

god, they darted over the glen with its streams and rocks. When they saw the king seated in the pine tree, they first climbed on the rock cliff that towered opposite and hurled stones at him with all their might and pelted him with branches of pines. Others hurled the thyrsus through the air at Pentheus, a pitiable target. (1082–1100)

But they were unsuccessful, for the poor wretch sat trapped and helpless, too high for even their fanaticism. Finally, with a lightning force they ripped off oak branches and tried to use them as levers to uproot the tree. But when these efforts too were all in vain, Agave exclaimed: “Come, O Maenads, stand around the tree in a circle and grab hold of it, so that we may catch the climbing beast and prevent him from revealing the secret revels of the god.” And they applied a thousand hands and tore up the tree out of the earth. And from his lofty seat, Pentheus fell hurtling to the ground with endless cries; for he knew what evil fate was near. (1100–1113)

His mother as priestess was the first to begin the slaughter. She fell on him, and he ripped off the band from his hair so that poor Agave might recognize him and not kill him, and he cried out as he touched her cheek: “Mother, it is your son, Pentheus, whom you bore in the home of Echion. Have pity on me for my sins and do not kill me, your son.” (1114–1121)

But Agave was not in her right senses; her mouth foamed, and her eyes rolled madly as the god Bacchus held her in his power. And Pentheus could not



Pentheus. Attic red-figure kylix by Douris, ca. 480 B.C. This drinking cup graphically depicts the dismemberment of Pentheus. The maenads on either side of Pentheus, wearing spotted animal skins, are wrenching his body apart. The maenad at which Pentheus seems to be gazing pleadingly has been identified as Agave. Others have been identified as Autonoë and Ino. The maenad at the far left is holding one of his limbs. At the right a satyr, with arms raised in excitement, is observing the sparagmos (the sacrificial rending of the victim). On the opposite side of the vase, between two maenads holding parts of Pentheus' body and unnervingly staring directly out at the viewer, sits Dionysus, enjoying his wine to the music of another satyr playing a double flute. On the tondo (within the center of the cup) is a swaying maenad holding a live leopard in one hand and a thyrsos in the other. (Kimbell Art Museum, Fort Worth, Texas/Art Resource, NY)

reach her. She seized his left arm below the elbow and placing her foot against the ribs of her ill-fated son, wrenched his arm out of his shoulder. It was not done through her own strength, but the god made it easy for her hands. From the other side, Ino clawed and tore at his flesh, and Autonoe and the whole pack converged on him. All shouted together, he moaning with what breath remained, they screaming in triumph. One carried an arm, another a foot with the boot still on; his ribs were stripped clean, and they all with blood-drenched hands tossed the flesh of Pentheus among them like a ball. His body lies scattered, some pieces under hard rocks, others in the shady depths of the woods—not easy to find. (1122–1139) 60

His mother has taken his poor head and affixed it on the point of her thyrsus; she carries it like that of a mountain lion through the depths of Cithaeron, leaving her sisters and their Maenad bands. She comes within these walls, exulting in her ill-fated prey and calling on Bacchus, her partner in the hunt, her comrade in the chase, her champion of victory, who gave her tears as her reward. And so I am leaving now, before Agave reaches the palace, to get away from this misfortune. Temperance and reverence for the gods are best, the wisest possessions, I believe, that exist for mortals who will use them. (1139–1152) 70

Agave returns and in a terrifying scene with her father Cadmus, she awakens from her madness to recognize the horror of her deed; it is the head of her son Pentheus, not that of a mountain lion that she holds in her hands. The conclusion of the play affirms the divine power of Dionysus. He appears now as god, the *deus ex machina*, to mete out his harsh justice against those who have denied his godhead and blasphemed his religion.

Pentheus has already died for his crimes; the other principal sinners must go into exile. Cadmus and Harmonia will experience much war and suffering in their wanderings and will be turned into serpents; but eventually they will be saved by Ares (the father of Harmonia) and transported to the Islands of the Blessed. Agave and her sisters must leave Thebes immediately. In her anguished farewell to her father, she utters this provocative commentary on her bitter and tragic experience with the religion of Dionysus.

May I reach a place where Cithaeron, that mountain polluted by blood, may never see me or I lay eyes upon it, where any record of the thyrsus is unknown. Let Cithaeron and the thyrsus be the concern of other Bacchic women, not me. (1383–1387)

There are serious textual problems in the last section of the play. A medieval work, the *Christus Patiens*, which drew upon Euripides, is of some help—an interesting fact that rivets our attention to the parallels between Dionysus and Christ.

The pathos and horror of the butchering of Pentheus have led some to advance a sympathetic view of the rash king as an ascetic martyr, killed in his crusade against the irrational tide of religious fanaticism. But too much in the makeup of this young man suggests the myopic psychopath who is unable to accept human nature as it is and foolishly tries to suppress it. The basic impulses toward both the bestial and the sublime are terrifyingly and wondrously inter-related; Dionysus is, after all, the god of mob fury and religious ecstasy and anything in between. Was the celebration of his worship a cry for release from

Harry Partch's American Bacchae

Harry Partch, the American composer, offers enlightening insights into elements of Dionysiac worship in his elucidation of his musical and theatrical Americanization of Euripides' tragedy, *Revelation in the Courthouse Park* (1960):

I first decided that I would bodily transfer Euripides' The Bacchae to an American setting. But in the end the better solution seemed to be to alternate scenes between an American courthouse park and the area before the palace of the city of Thebes. . . . I was determined to make this an American here-and-now drama, which, tragically, it truly is. . . . Many years ago I was struck by a strong and strange similarity between the basic situation in the Euripides play and at least two phenomena of present-day America. Religious rituals with a strong sexual element are not unknown to our culture, nor are sex rituals with a strong religious element. (I assume that the mobbing of young male singers by semihysterical women is recognizable as a sex ritual for a godhead.) And these separate phenomena, after years of observing them, have become synthesized as a single kind of ritual with religion and sex in equal parts, and with deep roots in an earlier period of evolution.⁷

The equation of the idolization of Elvis Presley with the worship of Dionysus has turned out to be more apt than Partch might even suspect. For the devout, Elvis either has never really died or has been resurrected, and he is still very much with us. Pilgrimages to his temple in Graceland are legion. The Dionysiac experience in relation to singers of popular music and rock has spanned more than one generation. It can be recognized in the bobby-soxers who swooned at the feet of Frank Sinatra and in the androgynous cults of Michael Jackson and Boy George, and it afflicts both sexes with equal passion. The furor aroused by the female singer Madonna or the rock group The Beatles devastates men and women equally, sometimes enhanced by the Dionysiac use of intoxicating drugs (see also the section on Harry Partch in Chapter 28 on the companion website). Every generation has its new idols.

the restraints of civilized society and a return to the mystic purity and abounding freedom of nature, or was it merely a deceptive excuse for self-indulgence in an orgy of undisciplined passion?

Other Opponents of Dionysus

At Tiryns in Argos the **daughters of King Proetus** resisted Dionysus, who caused them to rush over the countryside, leaving their homes and killing their children. In return for half of the kingdom, the famous seer **Melampus**, who, according to Herodotus (2.29) introduced the rituals of Dionysus to Greece, cured the madness of the daughters of Proetus by means of herbs and therapeutic dances.⁸ He joined a group of strong young men in performing a kind of war dance, although one daughter, Iphinoë, died during the pursuit. This myth was connected with the festival of the Agriania, which involved a ritual pursuit of women by night and a return the next day to the normal order of society. It was celebrated at Orchomenus and at many other places in Greece.

In Orchomenus, a city of Boeotia, the **daughters of Minyas** refused to participate in Bacchic worship but remained at home to weave. Dionysus, in the guise of a girl, warned them of their folly to no avail, and they were driven mad. One of them, Leucippe, bore a son named Hippasus, who (like Pentheus) was torn to pieces. Unlike the daughters of Proetus, the Minyads did not return to normal life. They became winged creatures of the night, either owls or bats. Clymene, however, one of the daughters of Minyas, appears as the wife of five different husbands and thus becomes both the aunt of Jason (through her marriage to Pheres) and the mother (by Iasus) of Atalanta. She also was loved by Helius to become the mother of Phaëthon.

Lycurgus of Thrace pursued the nurses of Dionysus with an ox goad, and Dionysus himself in terror jumped into the sea and was rescued and comforted by Thetis. The gods became angry with Lycurgus, and Zeus struck him with blindness and he died soon afterward.

The Nature of Dionysus, His Retinue, and His Religion

The *Homeric Hymn to Dionysus* (1)⁹ gives some variant information about Dionysus' birth, derives his name from Zeus (Dios) and the mountain Nysa (which is here placed in Egypt), and establishes the universal power of his worship.

O divinely born god, sewn in Zeus' thigh,¹⁰ some say it was on Dracenum, some in windy Icarus, some at the deep flowing Alpheus,¹¹ where Semele, made pregnant by Zeus who delights in the lightning, gave birth to you. Others say, O lord, that you were born in Thebes. They are all wrong; the father of both gods and men gave you birth, away from people and hidden from white-armed Hera. 10

There is a certain mountain, Nysa, very high and with verdant forests, far from Phoenicia, near the streams of Egypt.¹² (8–9)

“... and they will set up many statues in temples; and as things are three, mortals always, everywhere, will sacrifice perfect hecatombs to you in triennial festivals.”¹³ The son of Cronus spoke and nodded with his dark brows; and the divine hair of our lord flowed down around his immortal head and he made great Olympus shake. Thus speaking, wise Zeus nodded confirmation with his head. (10–16) 10

Be kind, you, sewn in Zeus' thigh, who drive women mad. We bards sing of you as we begin and end our song. It is utterly impossible for anyone who is forgetful of you to remember how to sing his holy song. (17–19)

So hail to you, Dionysus, sewn in Zeus' thigh, along with your mother, Semele, whom indeed they call Thyone. (20–21)

Another *Homeric Hymn to Dionysus* (26) tells us more about the god:

I begin to sing about ivy-crowned, loud-crying Dionysus, glorious son of Zeus and renowned Semele. The nymphs with beautiful hair took him to their bosoms from the lord his father and nurtured him tenderly in the vales of Mt. Nysa. By the grace of his father, he grew up in a fragrant cave, to be counted among the immortals. But when the goddesses had brought up this much-hymned god, then indeed he used to wander, heavily wreathed in ivy and laurel, among the

woodland haunts of the forest. The nymphs followed along, with him as leader, and the sound of their cries filled the vast forest. (1–10)

So hail to you, Dionysus, rich in grape clusters; grant that we may in our joy go through these seasons again and again for many years.

10

For a translation of Demosthenes' taunts about Dionysiac worship, see www.oup.com/us/morford.

The essential characteristics of Dionysiac religion are an ecstatic spiritual release through music and dance,¹⁴ the possession by the god of his followers, the rending apart of the sacrificial animal, and the eating of the raw flesh (**omophagy**, a kind of ritual communion, since the god was believed to be present in the victim). The religious congregation (the holy **thiasus**) was divided into groups, often with a male leader for each, who played the role of the god. The Bacchae, or **maenads**, are the female devotees, mortal women who become possessed. In mythology they are more than human, nymphs rather than mere mortals.

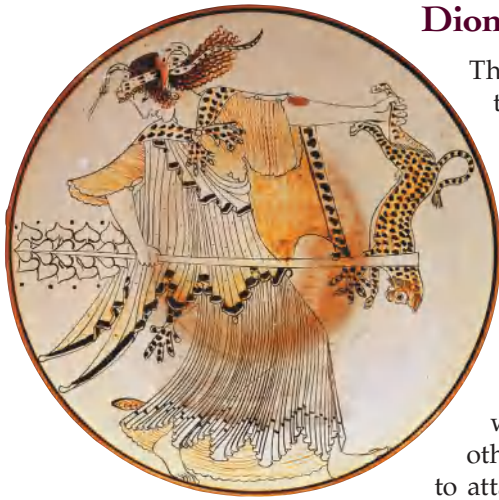
Their mythological male counterparts are **satyrs**, who, like them, are spirits of nature; they, however, are not completely human but part man and part animal, possessing various attributes of a horse or a goat—a horse's tail and ears, a goat's beard and horns—although in the later periods they are often depicted as considerably more humanized. Satyrs dance and sing and love music; they make wine and drink it, and they are perpetually in a state of sexual excitement. One of their favorite sports is to chase maenads through the woods. Animal skins and garlands are traditional attributes of Bacchic revelers (although satyrs are usually nude); maenads, in particular, carry the thyrsus, a pole wreathed with ivy or vine leaves, pointed at the top to receive a pine cone. As we have seen, it is a magic wand that evokes miracles, but if necessary it can be converted into a deadly weapon.

Sileni also attend Dionysus; they often cannot be distinguished from satyrs, although some of them are older (*papposileni*) and even more lecherous. Yet others are old and wise, like **Silenus** himself, the tutor of Dionysus. A story tells how once one of them was made drunk by drinking water from a spring laced with wine; when he was brought to **King Midas**, this Silenus philosophized that the best fate for human beings was not to be born at all and that the next best was to die as soon as possible after birth, providing a typical example of Greek pessimism and wisdom reminiscent of Solon and Herodotus.¹⁵ Dionysus and his retinue are favorite subjects in Greek art.

As the male god of vegetation, Dionysus was, as we should expect, associated with a fertility goddess; his mother, Semele, was a full-fledged earth deity in her own right before she became Hellenized. The story of Zeus' birth on Crete, with the attendants who drowned out his infant cries by their frenzied music, suggests contamination with Dionysiac ritual. Certainly, Euripides associates Bacchic mysticism with the ritual worship of both Rhea and Cybele. Dionysus' "marriage" with Ariadne, saving her after she was deserted by Theseus on the island of Naxos (see pp. 594–596), not only provides an example of the union of the male and female powers of vegetation but also illustrates allegorically his powers of redemption. Dionysus represents the sap of life, the coursing of the blood through the veins, the throbbing excitement and mystery of sex and of nature; thus he is a god of ecstasy and mysticism.



Dionysus and Satyrs. Red-figure kylix, by the Brygos painter, ca. 480 B.C. Some 200 vases have been attributed to this painter, who is best known for the liveliness of the poses and the exquisite rendering of the figures, particularly their faces. Here we see a Bacchic revel with Dionysus, wreathed with ivy, playing a lyre and throwing his head back with remarkable abandon. He is flanked by two typically Attic satyrs: balding, snub nosed, with goat's beard, but with the tail and ears of a horse. The satyr on the right wears the familiar dappled leopard skin. The satyr on the left holds a vine branch with leaves, forming the background. Both satyrs are dancing around the god with castanets.



Maenad. Interior of an Attic kylix by the Brygos painter, ca. 480 B.C.; diameter 11 ¼ in. This lively white-ground painting (the cup is signed by the potter Brygos) shows a maenad in violent motion, holding a thyrsus in her right hand and a small leopard in her left. A leopardskin is fastened over her dress, and a wreath of serpents encircles her head. (Erich Lessing/*Art Resource*, NY)

Dionysus Spiritualized as Zagreus

The essence and spirit of Greek drama are to be found in the emotional environment of Dionysiac ecstasy. Theories concerning the origins of this genre in its relationship to Dionysus are legion. But it is a fact that tragedy and comedy were performed at Athens in a festival in his honor. It is difficult to agree with those who feel that this connection was purely accidental. Certainly, Aristotle's treatise dealing with the nature of tragedy in terms of a catharsis of pity and fear takes for granted emotions and excitement that are essentially Bacchic.¹⁶

Another myth told about his birth even more clearly established Dionysus in this role as a god of the mysteries. Zeus mated with his daughter Persephone, who bore a son, Zagreus, which is another name for Dionysus. In her jealousy, Hera then aroused the Titans to attack the child. These monstrous beings, their faces whitened with chalk, attacked the infant as he was looking in a mirror (in another version, they beguiled him with toys and cut him to pieces with knives). After the murder, the Titans devoured the dismembered corpse.¹⁷ But the heart of the infant god was saved and brought to Zeus by Athena, and Dionysus was born again—swallowed by Zeus and begotten on Semele. Zeus was angry with the Titans and destroyed them with his thunder and lightning; but from their ashes humankind was born.

Surely, this is one of the most significant myths in terms of the religious dogma that it provides. By this myth human beings are endowed with a dual nature—a body gross and evil (since we are sprung from the Titans) and a soul that is pure and divine (for after all the Titans had devoured the god). Thus basic religious concepts (which lie at the root of all mystery religions) are accounted for: sin, immortality, resurrection, life after death, reward, and punishment. It is no accident that Dionysus is linked with Orpheus and Demeter and the message they preached. He is in his person a resurrection-god; the story is told that he went down into the realm of the dead and brought back his mother, who in this account is usually given the name Thyone.

Dionysus, Icarius, and Erigone

Dionysus, however, can be received amid peace and joy, although even then tragedy might result. In Attica, in the days of King Pandion, a man named Icarius was most hospitable to the god, and as a reward he was given the gift of wine. But when the people first felt the effects of this blessing, they thought they had been poisoned, and they turned upon Icarius and killed him. Erigone, his devoted daughter, accompanied by her dog Maira, searched everywhere for her father. When she found him, she hanged herself in grief. Suffering and plague ensued for the people until, upon Apollo's advice, they initiated a festival in honor of Icarius and Erigone.

Dionysus' Gift to Midas of the Golden Touch

We have learned how the philosophical Silenus was captured and brought to King Midas.¹⁸ Midas at once recognized the satyr as a follower of Dionysus and returned him to Dionysus. The god was so delighted that he gave the king

the right to choose any gift he would like for himself. Midas foolishly asked that whatever he should touch might be turned into gold. At first, Midas was delighted with his new power, when he saw that he could transform everything into gleaming riches by the mere touch of his hand. But the blessing quickly became a curse, for he could no longer eat or drink; any morsel or drop that he brought to his lips became a solid mass of gold. Midas' greed turned to loathing; in some accounts, even his beloved daughter was transformed. He begged the god's forgiveness for his sin and release from his accursed power. Dionysus took pity and ordered the king to cleanse himself of the remaining traces of his guilt in the source of the river Pactolus, near Sardis. Midas obeyed, and the power of transforming things into gold passed from his person into the stream, whose sands forevermore were sands of gold.

Dionysus and the Pirates

In the *Homeric Hymn to Dionysus* (7), the god is abducted by pirates who mistake him for a mortal. The ensuing events aboard ship offer a splendid picture of Dionysus' power and majesty and remind us of fundamental elements in the nature of his character and worship: miracles, bestial transformation, violence to enemies, and pity and salvation for those who understand.¹⁹

I shall sing of how Dionysus, the son of renowned Semele, appeared as a man in the first bloom of youth on a projecting stretch of shore by the sea that bears no harvest. His hair, beautiful and dark, flowed thickly about his head, and he wore on his strong shoulders a purple cloak. Before long, foreign pirates, led on by evil fate, appeared swiftly over the sea, dark as wine, in a ship with fine benches of oars. As soon as they saw him, they nodded one to the other and, quickly jumping out, seized him at once and put him on board ship, delighted in their hearts. For they thought that he was the son of kings, who are cherished by Zeus, and wanted to bind him in harsh bonds. But the bonds fell far from his hands and feet and did not hold him as he sat with a smile in his dark eyes. (1–15)

When the helmsman saw this, he called aloud to his comrades: "Madmen, who is this mighty god whom you have seized and attempt to bind? Not even our strong ship can carry him, for this is either Zeus or Apollo of the silver bow or Poseidon, since he is not like mortal men but like the gods who have their homes on Olympus. But come, let us immediately set him free on the dark shore; do not lay hands on him for fear that he become angered in some way and rouse up violent winds and a great storm." (15–24)

So he spoke, but the commander of the ship rebuked him scornfully: "Madman, check the wind, and while you are at it seize the tackle and hoist



Dionysus and Maenads.

Black-figure amphora by the Amasis painter, ca. 530 B.C. Dionysus, clothed in a chiton (a kind of long shirt) and himation (cloak) and holding a kantharos (cup) of wine, salutes two maenads, each clothed in a patterned peplos, who link arms and dance. They hold tendrils of ivy, and the one on the right holds a small deer by its ears. (Bibliothèque nationale de France)



Audio



Dionysus. Kylix by Exekias, ca. 530 B.C.; diameter 4 ½ in. The scene depicts the story told in the *Homeric Hymn to Dionysus*. The god reclines on the pirates' ship, round whose mast a grape-laden vine entwines itself. The crew have leaped overboard and have been transformed into dolphins. (Bildarchiv Preussischer Kulturbesitz/Art Resource, NY)

the sail. I expect that he will come with us to Egypt or Cyprus or the northern Hyperboreans or farther. But at his destination he will eventually tell us about his friends and all his possessions and his brothers, since a divine power has put him in our hands." When he had spoken, the mast and sail were hoisted on the ship; the wind breathed into the midst of the sail and the men made the ropes tight all around. (25–34)

But soon deeds full of wonder appeared in their midst. First of all, a sweet and fragrant wine flowed through the black ship, and a divine ambrosial odor arose. Amazement took hold of all the sailors as they looked, and immediately a vine spread in all directions up along the very top of the sail, with many clusters hanging down; dark ivy, luxuriant with flowers, entwined about the mast, and lovely fruit burst forth, and all the oarpins bore garlands. When they saw this, they ordered the helmsman to bring the ship to land. But then the god became a terrifying lion in the upper part of the ship and roared loudly, and in the middle of the ship he created a shaggy-necked bear, thus manifesting his divinity. The bear stood up raging, while on the upper deck the lion glared and scowled. (34–48)

The sailors fled into the stern and stood in panic around the helmsman, who had shown his good sense. The lion sprang up suddenly and seized the commander of the ship, but the sailors when they saw this escaped an evil fate and leaped all together into the shining sea and became dolphins. (48–53)

The god took pity on the helmsman and saved him and made him happy and fortunate in every way, saying: "Be of good courage, you who have become dear to my heart. I am loud-crying Dionysus, whom my mother, Semele, daughter of Cadmus, bore after uniting in love with Zeus." (53–57)

Hail, son of Semele of the beautiful countenance; it is not at all possible to forget you and compose sweet song.

Pan

The god Pan has much in common with the satyrs and silenoi of Dionysus.²⁰ He is not completely human in form but part man and part goat—he has the horns, ears, and legs of a goat; he will join in Bacchic revels, and he is full of spirit, impulsive, and amorous. His parents are variously named: his mother is usually some nymph or other; his father is very often Hermes or Apollo. Like them, he is a god of shepherds and a musician.

Pan is credited with the invention of his own instrument, the **panpipe** (or in Greek, **syrix**); Ovid tells the story with brevity and charm (*Metamorphoses* 1. 689–712). Syrix was once a lovely nymph, devoted to Artemis, who rejected the advances of predatory satyrs and woodland spirits. Pan caught sight of her, and as he pursued her, she was transformed into a bed of marsh reeds. The wind

blowing through them produced a sad and beautiful sound, and Pan was inspired to cut two of the reeds, fasten them together with wax, and thus fashion a pipe on which he could play.

Pan's haunts are the hills and the mountains, particularly those of his homeland, **Arcadia**, and he came to be especially honored in Athens. According to Herodotus (6. 106), Pan was encountered by the runner Phidippides, who had been sent to Sparta by the Athenians to ask for help when they were about to fight the Persians at Marathon in 490. Phidippides claimed that Pan called him by name and asked why the Athenians ignored him although he was a deity friendly to them. The Athenians believed Phidippides and later built a shrine to Pan, honoring him with annual sacrifices and torch races.

Pan had other loves besides Syrinx.²¹ His passion for the nymph **Echo** also ended tragically. She fled from his advances, and Pan spread such madness and "panic" among a group of shepherds (a particular feat to which he was prone) that they tore her to pieces. All that remained was her voice.

The *Homeric Hymn to Pan* (19) presents a memorable account of his birth and his revels; in this case, his father is Hermes and his mother Dryope, the daughter of Dryops.

Tell me, O Muse, about the dear son of Hermes—Pan, goat-footed, two-horned, lover of musical clangor—who wanders through wooded meadows together with a chorus of nymphs dancing along the heights of sheer rock. They call upon Pan, the splendid shaggy-haired god of shepherds, who has for his domain every snowy ridge, and mountaintops and rocky summits. He roams this place and

The Dionysiaca of Nonnus

Nonnus, a poet from Panopolis in Egypt, composed in the fifth century A.D. a Greek epic poem in forty-eight books on the theme of Dionysus and his exploits. In the "Mythical Introduction" to the three-volume Loeb text, H. J. Rose begins with this arresting statement: "The mythology of the *Dionysiaca* is interesting as being the longest and most elaborate example we have of Greek myths in their final stage of degeneracy."²² Full of learned information, this work does have its moments (often more academic than poetic) that justify proclaiming Nonnus "the last great epic poet of antiquity."

Book 1 begins with Zeus carrying off Europa, and Book 48 concludes with Dionysus' final return to Olympus, where he places the crown of his beloved Ariadne. Nonnus, in his varied and crammed tapestry of countless events, gives us information that is to be found nowhere else—for example, the fight between Dionysus and Perseus and the myth of Beroë, a child of Aphrodite, invented to afford Berytus, the site of a great Roman school of law, its very own foundation-myth. One should single out as well Nonnus' wealth of knowledge of astronomy, astrology, and religious doctrine, especially that of the Orphics. The amorous exploits of Dionysus seem endless, and a whole group of his lovers are all metamorphosed into various plants. Most interesting and bizarre of all Nonnus' excesses is the lengthy account of Dionysus as world conqueror, whose military conquests are obviously inspired by the legendary career of Alexander the Great. This same author Nonnus is credited with a poetic paraphrase of the Gospel of John.



Pan Pursuing a Goatherd, by the Pan painter, Attic red-figure krater, ca. 460 B.C.; height 14 1/2 in. Pan pursues a herdsman, possibly Daphnis, son of Hermes. Pan's intentions are clear, and his lust is wittily echoed by the herm (or, more likely, the figure of Priapus) in the rocky background. This is the reverse of the vase illustrated in Chapter 10 on page 227, which depicts the mortal Actaeon punished by the goddess Artemis. The impunity of divine lust contrasts with the tragic consequences of divine anger for human error. (Photograph © 2010. Museum of Fine Arts, Boston)

that through dense thickets; sometimes he is tempted by soft streams, and then again he passes among sheer rocks and climbs up to the highest peak that overlooks the flocks. Often he moves across gleaming high mountains; often, among the slopes, he presses on and, sharply on the outlook, kills animals. (1–14)

Then, in the evening only, returning from the chase, he plays a lovely tune on his pipe of reeds. Not even the nightingale, the bird that pours forth her sad lament in honeyed song amidst the petals of flower-laden spring, could surpass him in melody. With him then the clear-voiced mountain nymphs, moving on nimble feet, sing by a dark-watered spring; and Echo's wails reverberate around the mountaintop. The god Pan dances readily here and there among the chorus and then slips easily into their midst. He wears a spotted pelt of a lynx on his back, and his heart is delighted by his piercing tunes in a soft meadow where the crocus and fragrant hyacinth blooming at random mingle in the grass. (14–26)

They sing hymns about the blessed gods and high Olympus, and, above the rest, they single out Hermes, the bringer of luck. They sing how he is the swift messenger for all the gods and how he came into Arcadia, full of springs and mother of flocks, the place where his sacred precinct is located. There, even though he was a god, he tended the shaggy-fleeced sheep, in the service of a mortal. For a melting longing seized Hermes, and his passion to make love to the daughter of Dryops,²³ the nymph with the beautiful hair, intensified; and he brought to its fulfillment a fruitful marriage. (27–35)

Dryope bore to Hermes in their house a dear son, a marvel to behold right from his birth, a goat-footed, two-horned baby who loved music and laughter. But his mother was startled and fled, and she abandoned the child, for she was frightened when she saw his coarse features and full beard. Hermes, the luck-bringer, took him at once and clasped him in his arms; and the god felt extremely happy. Quickly, he covered the child in the thick skin of a mountain hare and went to the homes of the immortals and sat him down beside Zeus and the other gods and showed them the boy. All the immortals were delighted in their hearts, and especially Bacchic Dionysus; and they called him Pan because he delighted the hearts of them all.²⁴

So hail to you, lord. I pray to you with my song, and I shall remember both you and another song too. (35–49)

Echo and Narcissus

We know that because she rejected him, Pan caused Echo to be torn to pieces so that only her voice remained. A more famous story about Echo concerns her love for Narcissus. Ovid's version is as follows (*Metamorphoses* 3. 342–510):

The river-god Cephissus once embraced the nymph Liriope in his winding stream and, enveloping her in his waves, took her by force. When her time had come, the beautiful Liriope bore a child with whom even as a baby the nymphs might have fallen in love. And she called him Narcissus. She consulted the seer Tiresias, asking whether her son would live a long time to a ripe old age; his answer was: "Yes, if he will not have come to know himself." For a long time this response seemed to be an empty prophecy, but as things turned out, its truth was proven by the unusual nature of the boy's madness and death. (342–350)

The son of Cephissus had reached his sixteenth year and could be looked upon as both a boy and a young man. Many youths and many maidens desired him, but such a firm pride was coupled with his soft beauty that no one (either boy or girl) dared to touch him. He was seen once as he was driving the timid deer into his nets by the talkative nymph, who had learned neither to be silent when another is speaking nor to be the first to speak herself, namely, the mimic Echo. (351–358)

At that time, Echo was a person and not only a voice; but just as now, she was garrulous and was able to use her voice in her customary way of repeating from a flood of words only the very last. Juno brought this about because, when she might have been able to catch the nymphs lying on the mountain with her Jove, Echo knowingly detained the goddess by talking at length until the nymphs could run away. When Juno realized the truth, she exclaimed: "The power of that tongue of yours, by which I have been tricked, will be limited; and most brief will be the use of your voice." She made good her threats; Echo only gives back the words she has heard and repeats the final phrases of utterances. (359–369)

ECHO'S PASSION FOR NARCISSUS

And so she saw Narcissus wandering through the secluded countryside and burned with passion; she followed his footsteps furtively, and the closer she pursued him, the nearer was the fire that consumed her, just like the tops of torches, smeared with sulphur, that catch fire and blaze up when a flame is brought near. O how often she wanted to approach him with blandishments and tender appeals! Her very nature made this impossible, for she was not allowed to speak first. But she was prepared to wait for his utterances and to echo them with her own words—this she could do. (370–378)

By chance, the boy became separated from his faithful band of companions, and he cried out: "Is there anyone there?" Echo replied "There!" He was dumbfounded and glanced about in all directions; then he shouted at full voice: "Come!" She called back to him with the same word. He looked around but saw no one approaching; "Why do you run away from me?" he asked. She echoed his words just as he spoke them. He was persistent, beguiled by the reflection of the other's voice, and exclaimed: "Come here and let us get together!" Echo replied, "Let us get together," and never would she answer any other sound more willingly. She emerged from the woods, making good her very words and rushed to throw her arms about the neck of her beloved. But he fled and in his



Audio



Echo and Narcissus, by Nicolas Poussin (1594–1665); oil on canvas, ca. 1630, $29 \frac{1}{4} \times 39 \frac{1}{2}$ in. Narcissus lies along the edge of the pool with his flowers growing near his head, while Echo, waiflike, fades away in the background. The Cupid's burning torch is more fitting for a funeral than for a celebration of love. (Erich Lessing/Art Resource, NY)



Closer Look

flight exclaimed, “Take your hands off me; I would die before I let you possess me.” She replied with only the last words “Possess me.” (379–392)

Thus spurned, Echo hid herself in the woods where the trees hid her blushes; and from that time on she has lived in solitary caves. Nevertheless, her love clung fast and grew with the pain of rejection. Wakeful cares wasted away her wretched body, her skin became emaciated, and the bloom and vigor of her whole being slipped away on the air. Her voice and her bones were all that was left. Then only her voice remained; her bones, they say, were turned into stone. 50 From that time on, she has remained hidden in the woods; she is never seen on the mountains, but she is heard by everyone. The sound of her echo is all of her that still lives. (393–401)

Narcissus had played with her so, just as he had previously rejected other nymphs sprung from the waves or the mountains, and as well males who had approached him. Thereupon one of those scorned raised up his hands to the heavens and cried: “So may he himself fall in love, so may he not be able to possess his beloved!” The prayer was a just one, and Nemesis heard it. (402–406)

NARCISSUS' PASSION FOR HIS OWN REFLECTION

There was a spring, its clear waters glistening like silver, untouched by shepherds, mountain goats, and other animals, and undisturbed by birds, wild 60 beasts, and falling tree branches. Grass grew round about, nourished by the water nearby, and the woods protected the spot from the heat of the sun. Here

the boy lay down, tired out by the heat and his quest for game and attracted by the pool and the beauty of the place. While he was trying to quench his thirst, it kept coming back again and again, and as he continued to drink, he was captivated by the reflection of the beauty that he saw. (407–416)

He fell in love with a hope insubstantial, believing what was only an image to be real and corporeal. He gazed in wonder at himself, clinging transfixed and emotionless to what he saw, just like a statue formed from Parian marble. From his position on the ground he looked at his eyes, twin stars, and his hair, worthy of both Bacchus and Apollo, and his smooth cheeks, his ivory neck, and the beauty of his face, a flush of red amid snowy whiteness. He marveled at all the things that others had marveled at in him. Unwise and unheeding, he desired his very self, one and the same person approving and being approved, seeking and being sought, inflaming and being inflamed. How many times he bestowed vain kisses on the deceptive pool! How many times he plunged his arms into the midst of the waters to grasp the neck that he saw! But he could not catch hold of himself in their embrace. He did not understand what he was looking at, but was inflamed by what he saw, and the same illusion that deceived his eyes aroused his passion. (417–431)

Poor deluded boy, why do you grasp at your fleeting reflection to no avail? What you seek is not real; just turn away and you will lose what you love. What you perceive is but the reflection of your own image; it has no substance of its own. With you it comes and stays, and with you it will go, if you can bear to go. No concern for food or rest could drag him away from his post, but stretched out on the shady grass he looks at this deceptive beauty with insatiable gaze and destroys himself through his own eyes. He raised himself up a little and stretching out his arms to the surrounding woods exclaimed: (432–441)

“Has there ever been anyone smitten by more cruel a love? Tell me, O trees, for you know since you have provided opportune haunts for countless lovers. In the length of your years, in the many ages you have lived, can you remember anyone who has wasted away like me? I behold my beloved, but what I see and love I cannot have; such is the frustration of my unrequited passion. And I am all the more wretched because it is not a vast sea or lengthy road or impregnable fortress that separates us. Only a little water keeps us from each other. My beloved desires to be held, for each time that I bend down to kiss the limpid waters, he in return strains upward with his eager lips. You would think that he could be touched; it is such a little thing that prevents the consummation of our love. Whoever you are, come out to me here. Why, incomparable boy, do you deceive me? When I pursue you, where do you go? Certainly you do not flee from my youthful beauty, for nymphs loved me too. You promise me some kind of hope by your sympathetic looks of friendship. When I stretch forth my arms to you, you do the same in return. When I laugh, you laugh back, and I have often noted your tears in response to my weeping. And as well you return my every gesture and nod; and, as far as I can surmise from movements of your lovely mouth, you answer me with words that never reach my ears. I am you! I realize it; my reflection does not deceive me; I burn with love for myself, I am the one who fans the flame and bears the torture. What am I to do? Should I be the one to be asked or to ask? What then shall I ask for? What I desire is with me; all that I have makes me poor. O how I wish that I could escape from my body! A strange prayer for one in love, to wish away what he loves! And now grief consumes my strength; the time remaining for me is short, and my life will be

snuffed out in its prime. Death does not weigh heavily upon me, for death will bring an end to my misery. I only wish that he whom I cherish could live a longer time. As it is, we two who are one in life shall die together!" (442–473)

THE METAMORPHOSIS OF NARCISSUS

He finished speaking and, sick with longing, turned back again to his own reflection. His tears disturbed the waters and caused the image in the pool to grow less distinct. When he saw it disappearing, he screamed: "Where are you going? Stay here, do not desert me, your lover. I cannot touch you—let me look at you, give me this nourishment at least in my misery and madness." As he grieved, he tore his garment in its upper part and beat his bare chest with his marble-white hands. And his chest when struck took on a rosy tinge, as apples usually have their whiteness streaked with red, or grapes in various clusters when not yet ripe are stained with purple. As soon as he beheld himself thus in the water that was once again calm, he could endure it no further; but, as yellow wax is wont to melt under the touch of fire and the gentle frost under the warmth of the sun, so he was weakened and destroyed by love, gradually being consumed in its hidden flame. His beautiful complexion, white touched with red, no longer remained nor his youthful strength, nor all that he had formerly looked upon with such pleasure. Not even his body, which Echo had once loved, was left. (474–493) 120

When Echo saw what he had become, she felt sorry, even though she had been angry and resentful. Each time that the poor boy exclaimed "Alas," she repeated in return an echoing "Alas." And as he struck his shoulders with his hands, she gave back too the same sounds of his grief. This was his last cry as he gazed into the familiar waters: "Alas for the boy I cherished in vain!" The place repeated these very same words. And when he said "Farewell," Echo repeated "Farewell" too. He relaxed his weary head on the green grass; night closed those eyes that had so admired the beauty of their owner. Then too, after he had been received in the home of the dead below, he gazed at himself in the waters of the Styx. His sister Naiads wept and cut off their hair and offered it to their brother; the Dryads wept, and Echo sounded their laments. Now the pyre and streaming torches and the bier were being prepared, but the corpse was nowhere to be seen. They found instead a yellow flower with a circle of white petals in its center. (494–510) 140

Narcissism

This tragic story of self-love and self-destruction has cast a particularly potent spell on subsequent literature and thought, not least of all because of Ovid's perceptive and moving tale. The fact that it was a male lover's prayer for just retribution that was answered defines the homoerotic nature of Narcissus' self-love and self-destruction.²⁵ We do believe that Ovid intends us to understand that a male lover (*aliquis*) was rejected because then Narcissus' affliction becomes so ironic and so just: "Let the punishment fit the crime." The ominous words of Tiresias predict the tragedy in a fascinating variation of the most Greek of themes, "Know thyself," preached by Apollo and learned by Oedipus and Socrates. "When his mother inquired if Narcissus would live to a ripe old age, the seer Tiresias answered, "Yes, if he will not have come to know himself." We should not be surprised that Ovid is so profound.

“Narcissism” and “narcissistic” have been technical psychological terms and part of our everyday vocabulary since 1914, the year of Freud’s paper “On Narcissism: An Introduction.”²⁶

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Homeric Hymn 19	<i>To Pan</i>
Homeric Hymn 26	<i>To Dionysus</i>
Ovid	<i>Metamorphoses</i> 3.342–510

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Bacchylides	<i>Ode</i> 11.39–112 (How Hera drove the daughters of Proetus mad)
Euripides	<i>Cyclops</i> (Silenus and his satyr sons must serve the Cyclops Polyphemus)
Nonnus	<i>Dionysiaca</i>

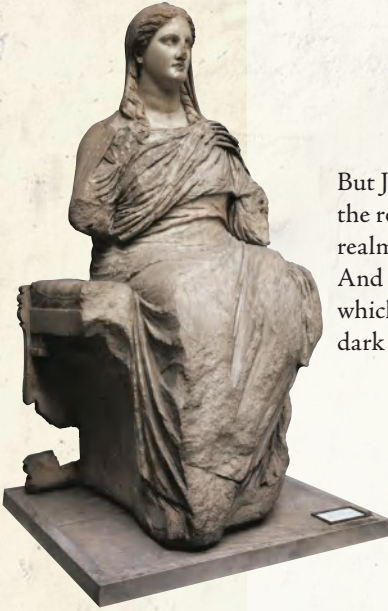
Notes

1. Bacchus, the name for the god preferred by the Romans, is often used by the Greeks as well.
2. The word *dithyrambos*, an epithet of Dionysus and the name of a type of choral poetry that included hymns sung in the god’s honor, was in ancient times believed to refer etymologically to his double birth.
3. The career of Ino is extremely confusing because of the multiple versions of her story. She was the second wife of Athamas (whom we shall meet again in the Argonautic saga), and they had two sons, Learchus and Melicertes. Angry with Ino because of

her care for Dionysus, Hera drove both Ino and her husband mad. Athamas killed his son Learchus and pursued Ino, who escaped with Melicertes in her arms. She leaped from a cliff into the sea and was transformed into the sea-goddess Leucothea; Melicertes also became deified under the new name of Palaemon.

4. Note the Dionysiac aspects of Orpheus' missionary zeal in Thrace, which establish the influence of the god there.
5. The Curetes, as we have seen, are the attendants of Rhea, who hid the cries of the infant Zeus from his father Cronus (see box, p. 75). In this passage, Euripides associates them with the Corybantes, the ministers of Cybele.
6. We have translated only the beginning and end of Tiresias' lengthy and learned sermon on the great power of Dionysus.
7. Harry Partch, *Bitter Music, Collected Journals, Essays, Introductions, and Librettos*, ed. Thomas McGeary (Urbana: University of Illinois Press, 1991), pp. 244–246. Reprinted from his *Genesis of Music*. 2d ed. (New York: Da Capo Press, 1974 [1949]).
8. Amphiaraüs, a seer and one of the Seven against Thebes, was a descendant of Melampus. The wife of Proetus, Stheneboea, is prominent in the myth of Bellerophon (see pp. 550–552).
9. The initial nine lines, quoted by Diodorus Siculus (3. 66. 3), are probably not a separate hymn but should in some way be joined to the fragmentary last section of this first hymn, which is found in manuscript.
10. The epithet *eiraphiotes* is of uncertain derivation. It may mean “insewn,” but it may instead refer to Dionysus' connection with the ivy plant or the goat or the bull.
11. Dracanum is a cape on the island of Cos; Icarus and Naxos are islands, and the Alpheus is a river in Elis.
12. There must be a lacuna after these lines from Diodorus and before the next section from the manuscript text.
13. The reference to three things is unclear; it may refer to the ritual of dismemberment.
14. E. R. Dodds' helpful edition of the Greek text of the *Bacchae*, 2d ed. (New York: Oxford University Press, 1960), includes an enlightening introduction. He notes that Dionysiac religion shares a belief, found universally, that musical rhythms and ritual dances lead to the most satisfying and highest religious experiences. See also Walter F. Otto, *Dionysus: Myth and Cult* (Bloomington: Indiana University Press, 1965 [1933]); M. Detienne, *Dionysos at Large* (Cambridge, MA: Harvard University Press, 1989 [1986]); Carl Kerényi, *Dionysos: Archetypal Image of Indestructible Life*. Translated from the German by Ralph Mannheim. Bollingen Series LXV.2 (Princeton, NJ: Princeton University Press, 1976); and Thomas H. Carpenter and Christopher A. Faraone, eds., *Masks of Dionysus*. Myth and Poetics Series (Ithaca, NY: Cornell University Press, 1993), a collection of essays about various aspects of Dionysus and his worship.
15. Vergil wrote a famous adaptation of this legend in his sixth *Eclogue*, in which the utterance of the silenus is cosmogonical and mythological.
16. Friedrich Nietzsche has provided the most imaginative and influential modern analysis of the Dionysiac experience, particularly in enunciating its antithetical relationship to the Apollonian. See M. S. Silk and J. P. Stern, *Nietzsche on Tragedy* (New York: Cambridge University Press, 1981), a study of Nietzsche's first book, *The Birth of Tragedy*.
17. Variations in the story are obviously etiological attempts to account for elements of Bacchic ritual. Later ceremonies enacted the passion, death, and resurrection of the god in all their details.
18. Ovid's version of Midas' story (*Metamorphoses* 11. 85–145) is well known. This is the same Midas whose ears were turned into those of an ass as a result of his preference for the music of Pan over that of Apollo (see pp. 265–266).
19. The same story is told by Ovid (*Metamorphoses* 3. 597–691), who provides an interesting comparison in artistic method and purpose.
20. See Philippe Borgeaud, *The Cult of Pan in Ancient Greece* (Chicago: University of Chicago Press, 1988) for a study of changing representations of Pan. See also Patricia

- Merivale, *Pan the Goat-God: His Myth in Modern Times* (Cambridge, MA: Harvard University Press, 1969).
21. Another nymph he pursued was turned into a tree that bore her name, Pitys (the Greek word for “pine”).
 22. Nonnos, *Dionysiaca*. Translated by W. H. D. Rouse (New York: Harvard University Press, 1934), vol. 1, p. x.
 23. This is Dryope; Ovid (*Metamorphoses* 9. 325 ff.) has a different version.
 24. The Greek word *pan* means “all.”
 25. See Louise Vinge, *The Narcissus Theme in Western European Literature Up to the Early 19th Century* (Lund, Sweden: Gleerups, 1967); also Gerasimos Santas, *Plato and Freud: Two Theories of Love* (Oxford: Blackwell, 1988). Freud believed (and of course many disagree) that an individual’s sexual development as an infant may determine his or her choices as an adult concerning the object and nature of love. Thus the theory of narcissism had a great impact on his conviction that, for some, relationships in love may stem not from their primal attachment to their mothers but from infantile self-love.
 26. See *The Standard Edition of the Complete Psychological Works of Sigmund Freud*, edited by James Strachey, vol. 14 (London: Hogarth Press, 1957), pp. 69–129. Of great interest is a biography of the psychoanalyst Heinz Kohut by Charles B. Strozier, *Heinz Kohut: The Making of a Psychoanalyst* (New York: Farrar, Straus & Giroux, 2001). Kohut became famous through his profound exploration of narcissism in papers such as “Forms and Transformations of Narcissism” (1966) and “The Analysis of the Self” (1971).



Demeter and the Eleusinian Mysteries

But Jupiter mediated between his brother and his sorrowful sister and divided the rolling year equally. Now the goddess, her divinity shared between two realms, lives with her mother for as many months as she lives with her husband. And suddenly the cast of her mind and face changed. For now her countenance, which could seem mournful even to Dis, is radiant as the sun, emerging from the dark clouds that had concealed it.

—OVID, *Metamorphoses* 5.564–571

The Myth of Demeter and Persephone

There are two *Homeric Hymns to Demeter*. Number 13 is a very short prelude.



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I begin to sing about the holy goddess Demeter of the beautiful hair, about her and her very lovely daughter Persephone. Hail, goddess; preserve this city and lead my song.

The lengthy and powerful *Homeric Hymn to Demeter* (2), by contrast, is of the utmost importance; it begins with Hades' abduction of Persephone at the will of Zeus:

I begin to sing about the holy goddess, Demeter of the beautiful hair, about her and her daughter, Persephone of the lovely ankles, whom Hades snatched away; loud-thundering Zeus, who sees all, gave her to him. (1–3)

Alone, away from Demeter of the golden scepter and goodly crops, Persephone was playing with the deep-bosomed daughters of Oceanus and picking flowers along a soft meadow: beautiful roses, crocuses, violets, irises, and hyacinths; and Earth in accordance with the

will of Zeus to please Hades, the host of many, produced as a snare for the fair maiden a wonderful and radiant narcissus, an awesome sight to all, both immortal gods and mortal humans. From its stem a hundred blossoms sprouted forth, and their odor was most sweet. All wide heaven above, the whole earth below, and the swell of the salt sea laughed. The girl was astounded and reached out with both her hands together to pluck the beautiful delight. And the wide-pathed Earth yawned in the Nysaeon plain, and the lord and host of many, who goes by many names, the son of Cronus, rushed at her with his immortal horses. And he snatched her up in his golden chariot and carried her away in tears. (4–20) 10

She shouted with shrill cries and called on father Zeus, the son of Cronus, the highest and the best, but no one of the immortals or of mortals—not even the olive trees laden with their fruit—heard her voice except for the daughter of Persaeus [Perseus], Hecate, her hair brightly adorned, who listened from her cave as she thought kindly thoughts, and lord Helios, the splendid son of Hyperion. These two heard the maid call on the son of Cronus, father Zeus; but he sat apart, away from the gods, in his temple with its many suppliants, receiving beautiful holy offerings from mortals. By the counsel of Zeus, his brother and her uncle Hades, the son of Cronus, who bears many names, the lord and host of many, led her off with his immortal horses against her will. (20–32) 20

As long as the goddess could behold the earth, starry heaven, the deep flowing sea full of fish, the rays of the sun, and still hoped to see her dear mother and the race of everlasting gods, hope soothed her great heart, although she was distressed. But the peaks of the mountains and the depths of the sea echoed with her immortal voice, and her lady mother heard her. (33–39) 30

DEMETER'S GRIEF, ANGER, AND RETALIATION

Sharp pain seized Demeter's heart, and she tore the headdress about her ambrosial hair with her own dear hands and threw off the dark covering from both her shoulders; and she rushed in pursuit, just like a bird, over land and water. But no one—either of gods or mortals—wished to tell what had really happened—not even a bird came to her as a messenger of truth. For nine days, then, lady Demeter roamed over the earth holding burning torches in her hands and in her grief did not eat any ambrosia or drink sweet nectar, nor did she bathe her body. But when dawn brought on the light of the tenth day, Hecate, a torch in hand, met her and gave her some news as she exclaimed: "Lady Demeter, bringer of goodly gifts in season, who of the heavenly gods or mortals carried off Persephone and troubled your dear heart? For I heard her voice but did not see with my eyes who it was. I am telling you the whole truth quickly." (40–58) 40

Thus Hecate spoke, and the daughter of Rhea of the beautiful hair did not answer but swiftly rushed away with her, holding burning torches in her hands. They came to Helios, the lookout for both gods and human beings, and stood before his horses, and the goddess of goddesses spoke: "Helios, do at least have respect for me, a goddess, if I have ever by word or by deed gladdened your heart and your spirits. Through the barren air I heard the piercing cry of the girl whom I bore, a sweet daughter, illustrious in her beauty, as though she were being violated; yet I saw nothing with my eyes. But since you look down from the divine aether with your rays on all the earth and sea, tell me truthfully if you 50

have seen my dear child at all and who, either of gods or mortals, has seized her alone, away from me, by force against her will and made away.” (59–73)

Thus she spoke. And the son of Hyperion answered her: “Demeter, regal daughter of Rhea of the beautiful hair, you will know the truth. For indeed I revere you greatly and I pity you in your grief for your daughter of the lovely ankles. No other of the immortals is to blame except the cloud-gatherer Zeus, who gave her to his own brother Hades to be called his lovely wife. And he seized her and with his horses carried her away to the gloomy depths below as she cried aloud. But, O goddess, desist from your great lament; you should not thus bear an unrelenting anger to no avail. Indeed Hades, the ruler over many, is not an unseemly husband for your daughter; he is your own brother and born from the same blood; and as for honor, when in the beginning power was divided three ways, his lot was to be made lord of all those with whom he dwelt.” (74–87) 60

Thus he spoke and called out to his horses. And at his cry they nimbly bore the swift chariot, just like long-winged birds. But a more dread and terrible grief possessed Demeter’s heart, and thereafter she was angry with the son of Cronus, Zeus, enwrapped in clouds; she kept away from the gatherings of the gods and high Olympus; and for a long time she went among the cities and rich fields of human beings, disguising her beautiful form. (88–94) 70

DEMETER COMES TO ELEUSIS AND THE PALACE OF CELEUS

No one of men or deep-bosomed women who saw her recognized her until she came to the home of wise Celeus, who at that time was ruler of fragrant Eleusis. Grieving in her dear heart, she sat near the road by the Maiden Well, from which the people drew their water; she was in the shade, for an olive tree grew overhead. Her appearance resembled that of a very old woman long past her days for childbearing and the gifts of garland-loving Aphrodite; she was like the nurses for the children of law-pronouncing kings or the housekeepers in their echoing halls. (94–104) 80

The daughters of Celeus, of the family of Eleusis, saw her there as they came after the easily drawn water so that they might bring it in their bronze pitchers to the dear home of their father. There were four of them, just like goddesses in their youthful bloom, Callidice and Cleisidice and lovely Demo and Callithoë, who was the oldest of them all. They did not know Demeter, for it is difficult for mortals to recognize the gods; and standing near they spoke winged words: “Who are you, old woman, of those born long ago? Where are you from? Why have you come away from the city and not approached the houses there, in whose shadowy halls dwell women just like you and younger, who would welcome you in word as well as in deed?” (105–117) 90

Thus they spoke. And she, the queenly goddess, answered with these words: “Dear children, whoever you are of women, I bid you greeting, and I shall tell you my tale. To be sure, it is not inappropriate to relate the truth to you who have asked. My name is Doso, for my lady mother gave it to me. Now then, I have come from Crete over the broad back of the sea—not willingly but against my wishes, for by force pirates carried me away. Then they put in at Thoricus, where the women and the men together disembarked; they were busy with their meal beside the cables of the ship, but my heart had no desire for the delicious food. I hastened away over the black land and escaped from my overbearing masters so that they might not sell me, whom they had not bought, and reap a profit from me. And so I 100



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have come here after my wanderings, and I have no idea at all what land this is or who inhabit it. But may all those who dwell in homes on Olympus grant that you have husbands and bear children just as parents desire. But you maidens pity me now and show concern until, dear children, I come to the home of a man and woman to perform for them zealously the tasks appropriate for an elderly woman like me; I could hold a newborn child in my arms and care for him well, make my master's bed in the recess of his well-built chambers, and teach the women their tasks." (118–144) 110

Thus spoke the goddess, and at once the virgin maiden Calliclida, the most beautiful of the daughters of Celeus, answered: "Good woman, we mortals, even though we suffer, must bear what the gods bestow, for indeed they are much the stronger. I shall help you with the following advice, and I shall tell you the names of the men who have great honor and power here and who are foremost among the people and guard the battlements of our city by their counsels and firm judgments. There is clever Triptolemus and Dioclus and Polyxeinus and noble Eumolpus and Dolichus and our own brave father. All of these have wives who take care of their homes, and no one of them at the very first sight of your person would dishonor you or turn you out of his house, but they will welcome you, for to be sure you are like one of the gods. But if you wish, stay here, so that we may go to our father's house and tell our mother, the deep-bosomed Metaneira, the whole story in the hope that she will bid you come to our place and not search for the homes of the others. She cherishes in our well-built house an only son, born late, a darling long prayed for. If you were to bring him up and he attained the measure of his youth, you would easily be the envy of any woman who saw you. Such are the great rewards that would be yours for your care." (145–168) 130

Thus she spoke, and Demeter nodded her head in agreement. And the girls filled their shining pitchers with water and carried them away happy. Quickly, they came to the great house of their father and told their mother at once what they had seen and heard. She enjoined them to go with all speed and to hire the woman at any price. Just as deer or heifers bound along the meadow when in the springtime they have had their fill of pasture, thus they hurried along the hollow wagon path, holding up the folds of their lovely garments, and their hair, which was like the flower of the crocus, danced about their shoulders. And they found the illustrious goddess where they had left her earlier and thereupon led her to the dear house of their father; she followed behind with her head veiled, distressed at heart, and the dark robe grazed the slender feet of the goddess. (169–183) 140

Soon they arrived at the house of Celeus, a man cherished by Zeus, and passed through the vestibule to where their lady mother sat by the pillar that supported the sturdy roof, holding her son, just a baby, in her lap. Her daughters ran to her, but the goddess stood at the threshold; her head reached up to the beams and she filled the doorway with a divine radiance. Then awe and reverence and fear seized Metaneira, and she sprang up from her couch and bade her guest be seated, but Demeter, the giver of goodly gifts in season, did not wish to sit on the splendid couch but waited in silence with her beautiful eyes downcast, until [the servant] Iambe in her wisdom set out for her a chair, artfully made, and threw a silvery fleece over it; then Demeter sat down, holding her veil over her face with her hands. (184–197) 150



Demeter. Marble, second half of the fourth century B.C.; height 58 in. This is the cult statue from the sanctuary of Demeter at Cnidus in Asia Minor. She is shown seated and heavily draped. Her solemn gaze and matronly clothing are consistent with the Demeter of the *Homeric Hymn to Demeter*. (© The Trustees of the British Museum)



Hades and Persephone, by Gian-Lorenzo Bernini (1598–1680); marble, 1621–1622; height 87 in. Bernini carved this statue for Cardinal Scipione Borghese; it was meant to be seen from the front, for it was placed against a wall. Hades has just seized Persephone and is entering his kingdom, indicated by its guardian, Cerberus, who is seen at the lower right. Persephone twists and cries out as she vainly attempts to escape the clutches of the god. Seen from the right side, the statue is yet more dramatic, for the impression of Hades' fingers sinking into Persephone's thigh and the open jaws of Cerberus (not shown here) heighten the viewer's pity and horror at the violence of the cruel god. (*Scala/Ministero per i Beni e le Attività culturali/Art Resource, NY*)

For a long time she remained seated without a sound, grieving; she did not by word or action acknowledge anyone; but without a smile, not touching food or drink, she sat wasted with longing for her deep-bosomed daughter, until Iambe in her wisdom resorted to many jests and jokes and brought the holy lady around to smile and laugh and bear a happy heart (thereafter, too, Iambe was to cheer her in her anguish). And Metaneira filled a cup with wine as sweet as honey and offered it, but she refused saying that it was not right for her to drink red wine. But she ordered them to mix meal and water with tender mint and give it to her to drink. Metaneira mixed the potion and gave it to the goddess as she had ordered. And the great lady Demeter took it for the sake of the holy rite.¹ (198–211)

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DEMETER NURSES DEMOPHOÖN

Beautifully robed Metaneira was the first to speak among them: "Greetings, O lady, I expect that you are not born of base parents but of noble ones. Majesty and grace shine clearly in your eyes as though from the eyes of royalty who mete out justice. But we mortals, even though we suffer, must bear what the gods bestow, for the yoke lies on our necks. Yet now since you have come here, as much as I have will be yours. Nurse this child, whom the immortals gave me late in life, fulfilling my desperate hopes and endless prayers. If you were to bring him up and he attained the measure of his youth, you would easily be the envy of any woman who saw you. Such are the great rewards that would be yours for your care." Then Demeter of the beautiful crown replied to her: "Sincere greetings to you, also, O lady, and may the gods afford you only good. I shall take the boy gladly, as you bid, and tend to him, and I have good hopes that he will

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not be harmed or destroyed by any evil charms, for I know much more potent remedies and effective antidotes for harmful spells." (212–230)

Thus she spoke, and with her immortal hands she took the child to her fragrant bosom. And his mother rejoiced in her heart. Thus she nursed in the house the splendid son of wise Celeus, Demophoön, whom beautifully robed Metaneira bore. And he grew like a god, not nourished on mortal food but anointed by Demeter with ambrosia, just as though sprung from the gods, and she breathed sweetness upon him as she held him to her bosom. At night she would hide him in the might of the fire, like a brand, without the knowledge of his dear parents. It was a source of great wonder to them that he grew and flourished before his time, for he was like the gods to look upon. And she would have made him immortal and never to grow old if beautifully robed Metaneira in her foolishness had not seen what was happening, as she watched in the night from her fragrant chamber. Great was her dismay, and she gave a shriek and struck both her thighs, terrified for her child. Amid her groans she uttered winged words: "Demophoön, my child, this stranger buries you within the blazing fire to my anguish and grievous pain." (231–249)

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Thus she spoke in agony, and the goddess of goddesses, Demeter of the beautiful crown, grew angry as she listened; with her immortal hands she snatched from the fire the dear son whom Metaneira had borne in her house, blessing beyond hope, and threw him down on the floor. Demeter was dreadfully angry in her heart as she spoke to beautifully robed Metaneira: "Mortals are ignorant and



Pluto and Proserpina by Jeff Koons; stainless steel brushed with yellow-gold paint; decorated with live flowering plants; height 129 in. Koons based his design on an eighteenth-century porcelain figurine. Using twentieth-century materials on a huge scale and twisting them to focus on the violence and speed of Pluto's (Hades') seizure of Proserpina (Persephone), he illuminates the mythical figures by the skillful use of gold color. (©Jeff Koons 2010–2013)

stupid who cannot foresee the fate both good and bad that is in store. Thus you in your foolishness have done a thing that cannot be remedied. I call to witness 200 by the relentless waters of the river Styx, the oath of the gods, that I would have made your dear child immortal and never to grow old all his days, and I would have granted him imperishable honor; but now, as it is, he will not be able to escape death and the Fates. Yet imperishable honor will always be his because he has lain on my knees and slept in my arms. But when the years go by and he has reached his prime, the new generation of Eleusinians will continually engage in dread wars and battles all their days. I am Demeter, esteemed and honored as the greatest benefit and joy to mortals and immortals. Now then, let all the people build to me a great temple and an altar with it, below the town and its steep wall,

on the rising hill above the well, Kallichoron. And I myself shall teach my rites, so that performing them with reverence you may propitiate my heart.” (250–274) 210

Thus the goddess spoke and cast aside her old age, transforming her size and appearance. Beauty breathed around and about her, and a delicious odor was wafted from her fragrant garments. The radiance from the immortal person of the goddess shone far and wide, and her golden hair flowed down on her shoulders. The sturdy house was filled with her brilliance as though with a lightning flash. She disappeared from the room, and at once Metaneira’s knees gave way; for a long time she was speechless and did not even remember at all to pick up her late-born son from the floor. But his sisters heard his pitiful cries and sprang down from their beds, spread well with covers; one of them then picked up the child in her arms and took him to her bosom, another stirred the fire, and a third hastened on her delicate feet to rouse their mother from her fragrant chamber. They gathered around the frantic child and bathed him with loving care. But his spirits were not soothed, for the nurses who tended him now were indeed inferior. (275–291) 220

The whole night long, trembling with fear, they made their supplication to the illustrious goddess, and as soon as dawn appeared they told the truth to Celeus, whose power was great, just as Demeter the goddess of the beautiful crown had commanded. Then Celeus called the many people to an assembly and bade them build a splendid temple to Demeter of the lovely hair and an altar on the rising hill. They listened to him as he spoke and immediately complied and did as they were told. And the child flourished by divine destiny. (292–300) 230

HADES AND PERSEPHONE AND HER EATING OF THE POMEGRANATE

When they had finished and ceased from their labor, each made his way homeward. But golden Demeter remained sitting there quite apart from all the blessed gods, wasted with longing for her deep-bosomed daughter. And she caused human beings a most terrible and devastating year on the fruitful land. The earth would not send up a single sprout, for Demeter of the lovely crown kept the seed covered. In vain the oxen dragged the many curved ploughs through the fields, and much white barley was sown in the earth to no avail. Now she would have destroyed the entire human race by cruel famine and deprived those who have their homes on Olympus of their glorious prestige from their gifts and sacrifices, if Zeus had not noticed and taken thought in his heart. First, he roused golden-winged Iris to summon Demeter of the lovely hair, desirable in her beauty. (301–315) 240

Thus he ordered. And Iris obeyed Zeus, the dark-clouded son of Cronus, and on swift feet traversed the interval between. She came to the citadel of fragrant Eleusis and found dark-robed Demeter in her temple. She spoke to her, uttering winged words: “Demeter, father Zeus, whose knowledge is imperishable, commands you to join the company of the eternal gods. Come now, let not the word I bring from Zeus be unaccomplished.” (316–323) 250

Thus she spoke in supplication, but Demeter’s heart was unswayed. Thereupon father Zeus sent down to her all the blessed gods who exist forever; and they came one by one, calling out her name and offering her many very beautiful gifts and whatever honors she would like to choose for herself among the immortals. But no one was able to sway her mind and her heart from her anger, and she stubbornly rejected all appeals. She maintained that she would never



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